

ing by 24 hours a day, only \$25 per round-term trade. I could have stuck with Prudential-Bache, since every big-time brokerage firm has a futures branch. But savvy short-term traders don't waste money on commissions, and Lind-Waldock was a discount broker.

Barry Lind, the president of Lind-Waldock, was trying to become the Charles Schwab of pork bellies. From the lobby of the Mercantile Exchange building, I reached him directly on the telephone. Try that with Mr. Merrill, Mr. Lynch, Mr. Prudential, Mr. Bache, Mr. Shearson, Mr. Lehman, Mr. Dean, Mr. Witter, Mr. Paine, Mr. Webber, or even Mr. Schwab. Right away, I sensed the accessibility, the informality, the friendliness of the futures and options people in Chicago.

Mr. Lind said he was Lear-jetting it out of town, so he passed me to his assistant, Chuck Epstein, the public relations director of the firm. Mr. Epstein's office was on the 17th floor of this glorified greenhouse. His walls were decorated with unusual posters, one of which asked: HOW COME THERE'S NO PEKING DUCK EXCHANGE? and another, HOW COME THERE'S NO HAVANA CIGAR EXCHANGE?" These depicted silly-looking Communists sitting around with nothing to trade, and had been commissioned by the Mercantile Exchange to show the advantages of free enterprise. I wanted to get some copies for myself, but Mr. Epstein said there'd been some complaints and the posters were discontinued.

We stood at a window while Mr. Epstein pointed out where the Fulton Street marketplace used to be. The egg stalls at the Fulton Street marketplace, Mr. Epstein said, had been the last remnants of the actual physical commodities that once made Chicago famous. Those were the days when an onion was an onion, and a bushel of corn had tangible properties. Now a bushel of corn had become a "form of settlement." So had hogs, and lumber, and baskets of stocks. What used to be called "farming" was dismissed as the "cash market."

Every futures contract was still called a "car," short for "carload," in memory of the days when commodities arrived here by rail, though the trains don't stop here anymore. Cattle traders make their living from "cars" of cattle without ever examining a cow. Soybean traders don't have to know a soybean from a rabbit pellet. Ask the local wheat trader where his cereal originates, and